Three Mistakes Families Make When the Conversation Turns to Assisted Living

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the habit that replaces it.

When the conversation turns to assisted living, most families start from the same three assumptions. Each one is easy to understand, and each has a better habit to put in its place.

1 Choosing from the label alone

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The social worker says “assisted living,” and by that evening you're reading about assisted living: what it is, which ones are near the house, whether she'd like the look of them. Nobody has yet written down what she needs help with.

WHY IT HAPPENS The name is the first concrete thing you've been handed, so it becomes the question. But a name describes a kind of place. It doesn't describe your wife, and it doesn't settle what a place provides: for assisted living, the National Institute on Aging says exact arrangements vary by facility and by state. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Before you read about any place, write the help she needs in tasks: which ones, what kind of help, and when you've seen it needed. The National Institute on Aging's first step in choosing a place is to consider the person's needs and wants. [2]

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2 Assuming every provider offers the same support

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A friend's mother lived in assisted living, where someone brought her pills each morning and walked with her to breakfast. You take it that any place with that name would do the same for your wife.

WHY IT HAPPENS The same name suggests the same service. The Family Caregiver Alliance says each state has different regulations for what is and is not provided, and that service can vary greatly. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Turn each must-have into a question and ask it of every place: can you do this, who does it, and at what hours? The National Institute on Aging tells families to mention any special needs or preferences when they call, and not to be afraid to ask questions. [2]

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3 Deciding what care she needs without professional input

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE After supper the family talks it through and arrives at an answer: she needs someone with her all day, or she'd be fine with a little help in the mornings. It gets said with confidence, and it becomes the plan.

WHY IT HAPPENS You know her days better than anyone, so it feels like yours to settle. But knowing her day isn't the same as assessing her, and the question is a hard one: the National Institute on Aging says it can be difficult to predict how much or what type of care a person might need. [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Bring what you've seen, and mark what is still a question. Anything about her health, her medications or how much supervision she needs goes to her doctor, her nurse, her therapist or your care consultant. The National Institute on Aging's advice when you're unsure is to ask a health care provider which services may be most helpful. [2]

The one habit behind all three

Describe the help before the place. Write what she needs in tasks, ask each place what it can do, and leave what it adds up to with the people who assess her.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say which kind of care or setting fits your wife, and it doesn't compare places. It names three assumptions, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to set down before you compare anything. The care interview puts a structured look at your wife's daily life in their place, area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

What the guide says about how arrangements vary, and the advice to consider needs first and to ask a health care provider, come from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. National Institute on Aging, Long-Term Care Facilities: Assisted Living, Nursing Homes, and Other Residential Care
2. National Institute on Aging, How To Choose a Nursing Home or Other Long-Term Care Facility
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Housing Options
4. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?

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